

Reading

PREPARING TO READ

- A BUILD VOCABULARY** The words in **blue** are used in the reading passage. Read the sentences below. Then write the correct form of each word or phrase next to its definition.

Don't let his words fool you—he's quite capable of being **deceptive**.
Kang Lee, a **prominent** psychologist, has researched lying in children extensively.
One can only **speculate** why habitual liars choose to lie even when there's no real benefit.
Young children have a **tendency** to lie to avoid getting into trouble.
The politicians were not able to **cover up** their lies and corruption.
It may be **reassuring** to learn that lying is a perfectly normal part of a child's behavior.
Most marriage experts say that honesty is the **foundation** of a healthy relationship.

- _____ (adj) important, well-known, or obvious
- _____ (phr) to try to hide bad behavior or wrongdoings
- _____ (n) the basic principle upon which something is developed or built
- _____ (adj) misleading; giving a false impression
- _____ (adj) comforting; offering a measure of relief
- _____ (v) to guess or hypothesize
- _____ (n) an inclination to do something often

- B BUILD VOCABULARY** Complete the sentences below with the correct form of the words and phrases in **blue**. Use a dictionary to help you.

fundamental (adj)	impede (v)	implicit (adj)	lessen (v)
prone to (adj)	systematically (adv)	twist (n)	universally (adv)

- Their progress was _____ by the bad weather.
- She's careless and _____ making mistakes.
- We thought we could solve the problem without a plan, but soon realized we needed to approach it more _____.
- Teamwork and trust were _____ to the success of the project.
- She told a few white lies to _____ the impact of the bad news.
- She smiled as she spoke, but her words contained a(n) _____ threat.
- Nobody expected the clever _____ at the end of the story.
- The idea is now _____ accepted in the scientific community.

C USE VOCABULARY Note answers to the questions below. Then discuss with a partner.

1. Are people in certain professions more **prone to** lying than others? Why do you think so?

2. What are some ways in which people **cover up** lies?

3. What are some **deceptive** claims or messages you've encountered?

4. Do you know of any **prominent** people who have been caught lying? Give examples.

D PREDICT Work with a partner. Make a list of things that people often lie about. Note your ideas below.

Critical Thinking

Check your ideas as you read the passage. Were any mentioned? What other ideas are mentioned in the passage?



The “dieselgate” scandal—in which many car makers were caught cheating in emission tests—was an example of a cover-up.

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WHY WE LIE

by Yudhijit Bhattacharjee

Honesty may be the best policy, but scheming and dishonesty may be part of what makes us human.

- A**  The history of humankind is filled with skilled and practiced liars. Many are criminals who spin lies and weave **deceptive** tales to gain unjust rewards. Some are politicians who lie to gain power, or to cling to it. Sometimes people lie to boost their image, while others lie to **cover up** bad behavior. Even the academic science community—a world largely devoted to the pursuit of truth—has been shown to contain a number of deceivers. But the lies of impostors, swindlers, and boasting politicians are just a sample of the untruths that have characterized human behavior for thousands of years.
- B** Lying, it turns out, is something that most of us are very skilled at. We lie with ease, in ways big and small, to strangers, co-workers, friends, and loved ones. Our capacity for lying is as **fundamental** to us as our need to trust others. Being deceitful is part of our nature, so much so that we might say that to lie is human.
- C** Our natural **tendency** to lie was first **systematically** documented by Bella DePaulo, a social psychologist at the University of California, Santa Barbara. Two decades ago, DePaulo and her colleagues asked 147 adults to note down every instance they lied or tried to mislead someone during one week. The researchers found that the subjects lied on average one or two times a day. Most of these untruths were harmless, intended to hide one's failings or to protect the feelings of others. Some lies were excuses—one person blamed their
- failure to take out the garbage on not knowing where it needed to go. Yet other lies—such as a claim of being a diplomat's son—were told to present a false image. While these were minor transgressions, DePaulo and other colleagues observed [in a later study] that most people have, at some point, told one or more “serious lies”: hiding an affair from a husband or wife, for example, or making false claims on a college application.
- D** That human beings should **universally** possess a talent for deceiving one another shouldn't surprise us. Researchers **speculate** that lying as a behavior arose not long after the emergence of language. The ability to manipulate others without using physical force may have helped us compete for resources—something similar to the evolution of deceptive strategies like camouflage¹ in the animal kingdom. “Lying is so easy compared to other ways of gaining power,” notes ethicist² Sissela Bok of Harvard University, one of the most **prominent** thinkers on the subject. “It's much easier to lie in order to get somebody's money or wealth than to hit them over the head or rob a bank.”
- E** As dishonesty has come to be recognized as a fundamental human trait, social science researchers and neuroscientists have sought to understand the nature and roots of the behavior. How and when do we learn to lie? What are the psychological **foundations** of dishonesty? And why do we believe lies so easily?

¹ Camouflage is the way in which some animals are colored and shaped so that they cannot easily be seen in their surroundings.

² An ethicist is someone who studies questions about what is morally right and wrong.

F Lying is something of a developmental milestone—like learning to walk and talk. Parents often find their children’s lies troubling, as they signal the beginning of a loss of innocence.³ However, Kang Lee, a psychologist at the University of Toronto, sees the emergence of the behavior in toddlers as a **reassuring** sign that their cognitive growth is on track.

G To study lying in children, Lee and his colleagues use a simple experiment. They ask kids to guess the identity of hidden toys, based only on an audio clue. For the first few toys, the clue is obvious—a bark for a dog, a meow for a cat—and the children answer easily. Then they play a sound that has nothing to do with the toy. “So you play Beethoven, but the toy’s a car,” Lee explains. The experimenter leaves the room pretending to take a phone call—a lie for the sake of science—and asks the child not to peek⁴ at the toy. Returning, the experimenter asks the child for the answer, then follows up with the question: “Did you peek?”

H Using hidden cameras, Lee and his researchers have discovered that the majority of children can’t resist peeking.

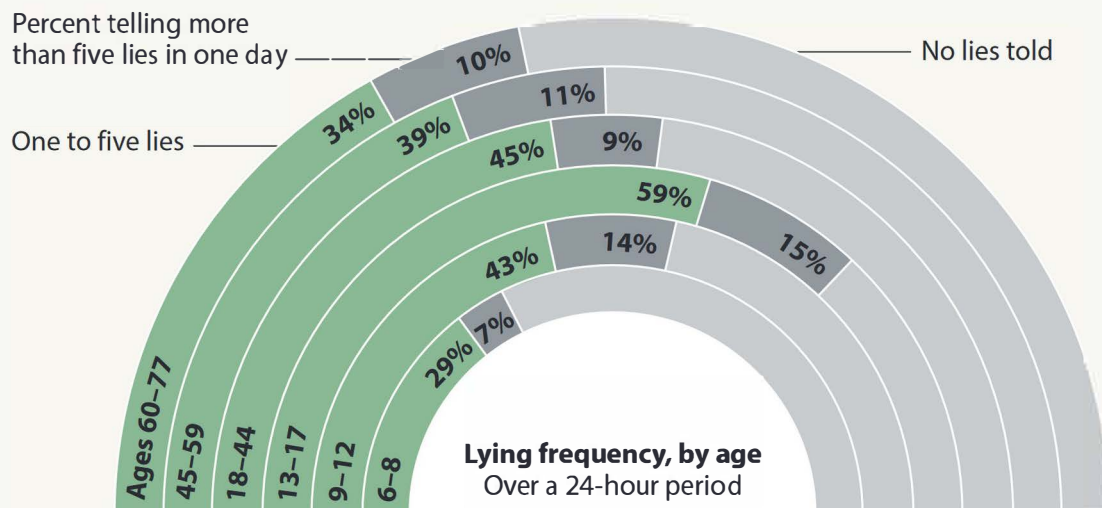
The percentage of children who peek and then lie about it depends on their age. Among two-year-olds who peek, only about one third lie about it. Among three-year-olds, half lie. And by age eight, approximately 80 percent claim they didn’t peek.

I Kids also get better at lying as they get older. When asked to guess the identity of the toy that they have secretly looked at, three- and four-year-olds typically give the right answer straightaway—they don’t realize that this reveals that they cheated. At seven or eight, kids learn to deliberately give a wrong answer at first, or they try to make their answer seem like a reasoned guess.

J Five- and six-year-old kids fall in between. In one study, Lee used a Barney The Dinosaur toy. One five-year-old girl denied that she had looked at the toy, which was hidden under a cloth. Then she told Lee she wanted to feel it before guessing. “So she puts her hand underneath the cloth, closes her eyes, and says, ‘Ah, I know: it’s Barney,’” Lee recalls. “I ask, ‘Why?’ She says, ‘Because it feels purple.’”

³ **Innocence** is the state of being morally pure and incapable of immoral behavior.

⁴ If you peek at something, you have a quick look at it, often secretly.





▲ **Lying for self-aggrandizement:** Mark Landis spent nearly three decades forging the works of famous painters. While he did profit substantially from this, he was also motivated by the admiration his imitations received.

K What drives this increase in lying sophistication⁵ is the development of a child's ability to put himself or herself in someone else's shoes. Known as "theory of mind," this is the facility we acquire for understanding the beliefs, intentions, and knowledge of others. Also fundamental to lying is the brain's executive function: the abilities required for planning, making decisions, and self-control. This explains why the two-year-olds who lied and lied well in Lee's experiments performed better on tests of theory of mind and executive function than those who didn't.

L As we grow older, much of the knowledge we use to navigate the world comes from what others tell us. Without

the **implicit** trust that we place in human communication, we would be paralyzed⁶ as individuals and cease to have social relationships. "We get so much from believing, and there's relatively little harm when we occasionally get duped," says Tim Levine, a psychologist at the University of Alabama.

M Being programmed to trust makes us naturally gullible.⁷ "If you say to someone, 'I am a pilot,' they are not sitting there thinking: 'Maybe he's not a pilot. Why would he say he's a pilot?' They don't think that way," says Frank Abagnale, Jr. Now a security consultant, Abagnale's cons⁸ as a young man—including forging checks and pretending

⁵If something has a high level of **sophistication**, it is more advanced or complex than other things.

⁶If you are **paralyzed**, you are unable to act or function properly.

⁷If someone is **gullible**, they can be tricked easily.

⁸Short for **confidence trick**, a **con** is a trick in which someone deceives you with the intention of gaining money.

to be an airline pilot—inspired the 2002 movie *Catch Me If You Can*. “This is why scams work,” he says. “When the phone rings and the caller ID says it’s the Internal Revenue Service,⁹ people automatically believe it is the IRS. They don’t realize that someone could manipulate the caller ID.”

N Robert Feldman, a psychologist at the University of Massachusetts, calls that “the liar’s advantage.” “People

are not expecting lies, people are not searching for lies,” he says, “and a lot of the time, people want to hear what they are hearing.” We put up little resistance¹⁰ to the deceptions that please or comfort us—such as false praise or the promise of impossibly high investment returns. And when we deal with people who have wealth, power, and status, the lies appear to be even easier to swallow.

⁹In the United States, the Internal Revenue Service (IRS) is the government authority that collects taxes.

¹⁰To put up resistance to something means to refuse to accept it and to try to prevent it.

Lying to entertain: Apollo Robbins and Ava Do, who are married, are performers who use deception to entertain and educate. Robbins is an astonishingly agile pickpocket, while Do is a magician.



o Researchers are now learning that we are **prone to** believe some lies even when they're clearly contradicted by evidence. These insights suggest that our skill at deceiving others—combined with our vulnerability¹¹ to being deceived—is especially consequential in the age of social media. Research has shown, for example, that we are especially prone to accepting lies that affirm our worldview. False news stories thrive on the internet and in social media because of this vulnerability, and disproving them does not tend to **lessen** their power. This is because people assess the evidence presented to them through a framework of preexisting beliefs and prejudices, says George Lakoff, a cognitive linguist at the University of California, Berkeley. “If a fact comes in that doesn’t fit into your frame, you’ll either not notice it, or ignore it, or ridicule it, or be puzzled by it—or attack it if it’s threatening.”

P What then might be the best way to **impede** the rapid advance of untruths into our collective lives? The answer isn’t clear. Technology has opened up a new frontier for deceit, adding a 21st-century **twist** to the age-old conflict between our lying and trusting selves.

Adapted from “Why We Lie,” by Yudhijit Bhattacharjee: National Geographic Magazine, June 2017

Yudhijit Bhattacharjee is an award-winning writer whose features and essays on science, espionage, cybercrime, and medicine have appeared in *The New Yorker*, *The New York Times Magazine*, *National Geographic*, *Wired*, and other publications.

¹¹To have a vulnerability is to be open to harm in a certain way.



▲ **Lying for fun:** Jacob Hall’s tall tales have won him numerous awards, including West Virginia’s “Biggest Liar” award. According to Hall, “My stories would be pretty boring without deception.”

UNDERSTANDING THE READING

A UNDERSTAND MAIN IDEAS Check (✓) the four topics that the writer covers in the reading passage.

- ☐ 1. the reasons that people lie
- ☐ 2. how often people lie
- ☐ 3. why people believe lies
- ☐ 4. cross-cultural differences in lying
- ☐ 5. the emotional effects of lying and being deceptive
- ☐ 6. the relationship between lying and cognitive development

B UNDERSTAND DETAILS Read paragraphs L–O of the reading passage and complete the summary. Use no more than two words from the reading passage for each answer.

We can't function in life without trust because a lot of the ¹_____ we need comes from other people. We therefore generally trust people because the benefits of doing so significantly outweigh the harm of occasionally being tricked or lied to. However, this tendency to trust does leave people ²_____. According to Frank Abagnale, Jr., this is why scams work. Psychologist Robert Feldman refers to this as the ³_____. People do not usually expect or look for lies. Furthermore, they are often happy to hear them—especially lies that comfort, praise, or promise high returns on investments. These lies are even more believable when told by people with wealth, power, and status. Today, in the age of social media, people are more likely to believe lies, especially ones that support their ⁴_____. These lies flourish online, and ⁵_____ them does not reduce their effectiveness. This is because we interpret ⁶_____ based on our beliefs and biases. If a fact does not match what we believe, we simply dismiss, ridicule, or attack it.

Critical Thinking

C INFER MEANING Find and underline the following words and phrases in the reading passage. Use the context to identify their meanings. Then match each word or phrase to its definition.

unjust (paragraph A)

milestone (paragraph F)

impostor (paragraph A)

on track (paragraph F)

transgression (paragraph C)

get duped (paragraph L)

1. _____ an action that is wrong or immoral
2. _____ a person who pretends to be someone else
3. _____ an important event in the development of something
4. _____ not fair
5. _____ following a course likely to result in success
6. _____ to be tricked into believing something that is not true